Probing questions

Moving beyond the first answer

Use probing questions after students have relevant knowledge to deepen or clarify the reasoning behind an answer. Plan a focused follow-up rather than asking a vague “Why?” every time.

How to do it well

1 Establish the knowledge. Explain or model the method, concept or example before asking pupils to reveal how it works.

2 Anchor the probe. Begin from a pupil answer, a worked step, a comparison or a decision the class can see.

3 Ask one focused how or why. Target the clue used, the first step, the reason for a choice, a link to prior knowledge or an error that must be corrected.

4 Refine and rehearse. Prompt the pupil to add evidence, use precise vocabulary, sequence the explanation or improve it after hearing a peer.

5 Return to the process. Revisit the reasoning in a related example so the method becomes transferable rather than a one-off performance.

What this sounds like

“You chose the second source. Which feature makes it more trustworthy for this question? What evidence would weaken your judgement?”

Classroom example. A pupil identifies the correct result but offers little reasoning. The teacher asks which feature ruled out the alternative, then asks the pupil to complete the explanation using the key term. Another pupil compares the reasoning with a second case. The follow-up deepens a specific decision instead of becoming a vague extended interrogation.

Top tips that make the technique work

Probe a consequential decision. Ask which clue, criterion or relationship produced the answer.

Plan likely follow-ups. Prepare a question for an incomplete answer, a misconception and a secure explanation.

Hold the pupil’s thinking. Give a prompt, then return to the same student to complete the response.

Use precise language. “Which feature ruled out A?” is often clearer than “Tell me more.”

Involve listeners. Ask others to restate, compare or challenge the reasoning before moving on.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Anchor the probe to a visible answer or step.	Asking students to reason about untaught material.
Prompt a fuller disciplinary explanation.	Finishing their answer for them and accepting your own explanation.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Process Questions | Barton - Plan follow-up questions in advance